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Hollerbeier Haven

Living Deitsch Wisdom in the 21st Century

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Die Volkstimme



Farming must be on the side of religion, poetry and the arts rather than on the side of business, if ever the two sides conflict. "
--Lord Northbourne Look to The Land

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The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts is recording stories, interviews, memories, and knowledge of the healing traditions of Pow-wow or Braucherei. We are creating an archive of this tradition in order to preserve our heritage and ensure the practice. If you know anyone who practices or has a story to tell, we'd love to hear from you; whether you'd like to give a personal interview or prefer to remain anonymous, simply write to us. Your personal experiences are culturally valuable and will be treated with the utmost respect. You can contact us with questions or information by writing to:

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The quote on the cover is only a part of this complete quote:

"Is farming merely a necessary drudgery, to be mechanized so as to employ a minimum of people, to be standardized and run in ever bigger units, to be judged by cost accounting only? Or is it the only alternative to national decay to make farming something real for every man and near to him in his life, and something in which personal care, and possibly even poetic fancy, counts…? …Farming must be on the side of religion, poetry and the arts rather than on the side of business, if ever the two sides conflict. "

--Lord Northbourne

Look to The Land

It is with this quote in mind that I send forth this issue of Hollerbeier Haven. Farming has always been an essential and defining characteristic of the Pennsylvania Deitsch way of life. In the time that the Deitsch have been on Pennsylvania soil, however, the face of farming has changed dramatically. The Deitsch lived in a way that was close to the land and understood that what is good for the land was good for the farmer and ultimately good for all the people of a region. There has been a disconnect. Modern mechanized farming is not on the side of the land or the farmer or the community, it is on the side of the dollar. It is a sad state when multinational corporations have control even of the family farm. This issue focuses on food because it is through the purchasing of our food that we make choices that echo from the hand of the farmer receiving the dollar to the global ecosystem as a whole.

+ + + Jesse Tobin, Editor + + +

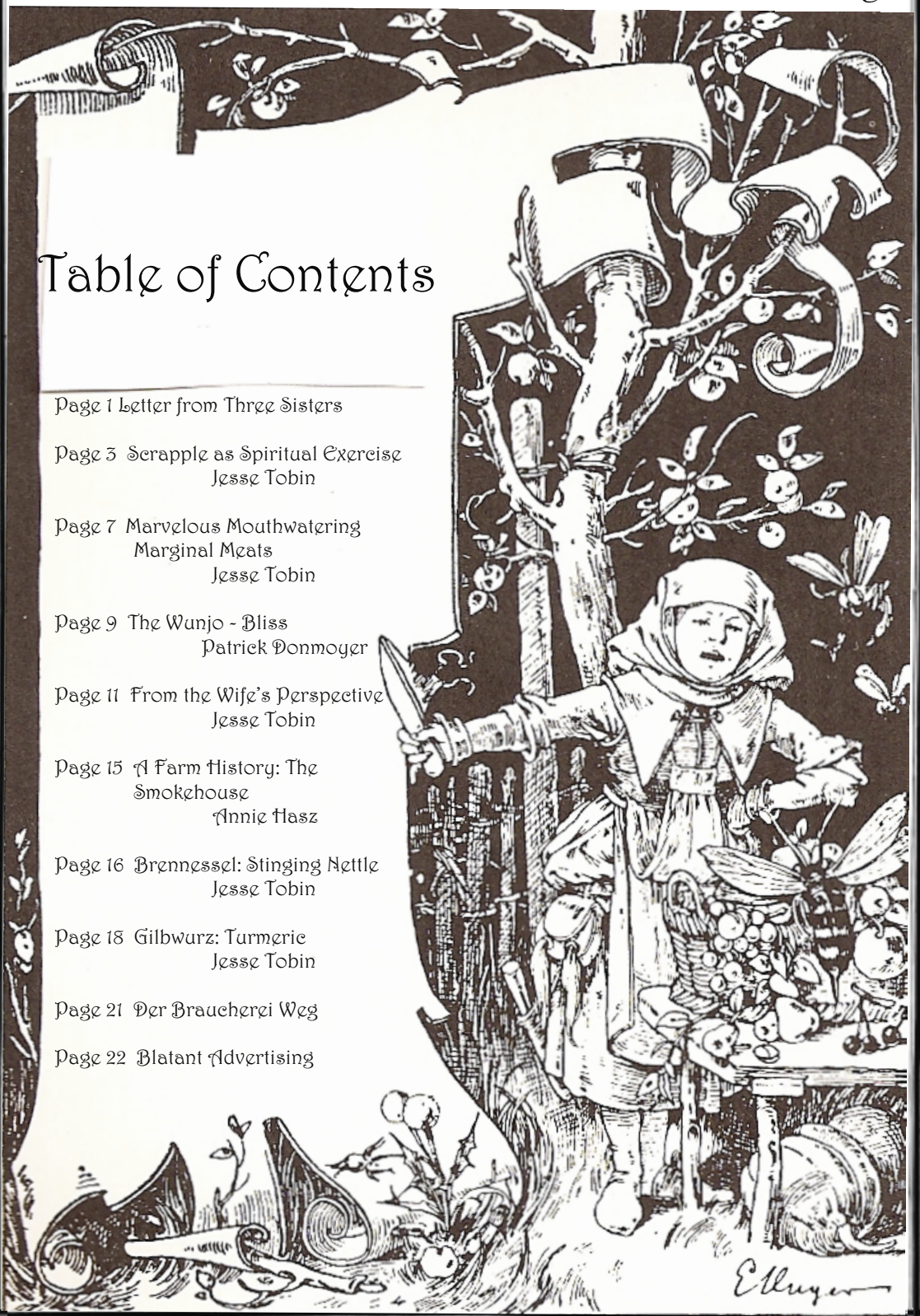


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Scrapple as Spiritual Exercise By Jesse Tobin



On the whole, meat is a vital element in traditional Deitsch cuisine, and the same is true generally for the vast majority of American cooking. Hardly a meal goes by without a main course of some sort of mouthwatering meat. Sure the vegetables and carbohydrates accentuate, compliment, and augment the fare, but let's not fool ourselves: the meat is what matters. Due to this reality the majority of the meat sold in grocery stores and butcher's shops are "choice cuts", particularly tender or mild flavored cuts for the mild mannered American pallet. Most American palettes have moved away from traditional fare, with its pigs feet, tongue, liverwurst, and blood pudding. As incomes have gone up, most people choose to spend their hard-earned dollars on cuts of meat with more social standing. Traditional composite meat

products (except the hotdog, for some reason) have been put on the back shelf, and are rarely reached for.

Bearing this in mind let us contemplate the problem before us: there are millions of human mouths to feed, yet there is only so much of any given cow, pig, sheep, or fowl that can be turned into a "choice cut". Only so many steaks, chops, tenderloins, can be found within each slaughtered animal. There are the complex emotions that come along with the eating of meat, and due to this most Americans tend to be uninvolved in the raising, slaughtering, and processing of meat. There is something in us that recognizes the living spirit in animals. At the same time, being omnivores generally, we find ourselves in a position where we must eat meat in order to remain healthy and vital. How can we resolve this conundrum?

I am writing today to encourage a return movement to traditional food. Traditional Deitsch meats (much like the meaty bits of all other cultures) certainly include the steaks and chops, but there is so much more to be explored and enjoyed. More importantly, traditional meats like scrapple, pig's feet, and liver pudding offer an opportunity for the meat eaters of the world to be more responsible in their consumption, and to give a greater respect for the slaughtered animals by ensuring that no part is wasted.

Meat requires a huge amount of resource input per pound of yield. Those of us who are attempting to shrink our ecological footprint find that there is a difficult balance with regard to our diets: we must enough meat to have our nutritional needs met, but not so much that we are wreaking havoc on the planet. In the meat industry there is so much potential for waste. This meat waste is not the inert, impersonal waste of other industries, wasted meat is wasted lives.

Each animal that has given its own life for the benefit of ours has given a gift that ought to be deeply respected and honored. Our Deitsch ancestors understood this fact, and respected the life-sustaining gift of meat by using every part: there are the chops and steaks, to be sure, but then we have roasts, stews, and pies as well. Those parts that seem less appetizing (like pig's feet) are cooked down with saurkraut, or ground and made into sausage. Then we have the pickled meats: the tripe, pickled pig's feet, lamb's tongues, and eyes. Of course, I can't leave out the composite meats: hotdogs are okay for most people, but scrapple, souse, tripe, blood pudding, and liverwurst are positively too much for many people to handle. This in particular is very strange to me: scrapple is clearly off the menu for the average American, but boloney, salami, spam, and a wide variety of cold cuts and lunch meats seem to be okay. Is there a difference in the constitution? Hardly. Perhaps the biggest difference is that the traditional meats made by local butchers are less likely to contain the various preservatives, fillers, and chemicals that are found in the prepackaged deli meats in the super market.

Last but not least are many cuts that taste wonderful when a soul is simply so brave as to give them a try, but seem unsavory simply due to the images and concepts they conjure: heart, liver, kidney, brains, rocky mountain oysters, and tongue. I can attest that many of these meats are delicious, but serve them up at a dinner party and you are bound to have a

room full of people who are suddenly not hungry.

It is this last category of meats that are of particular importance. These organ meats (popularly called “ouful”) are extremely rich in nutrients, allowing a person to fulfill their nutritional needs for a day or week in one meal. Often the nutrients found in these meats are precisely the nutrients and vitamins that most americans are deficient in. For instance: liver is so high in vitamins A and D that pregnant women have to be careful how much of this meat they eat, as excessive amounts of these vitamins have the potential to harm the fetus. On the other side of things, the average American is extremely deficient in viatmins A and D. This deficiency can have a wide ranging effect on health: from accentuating depressive tendencies to promoting inflammation generally (which can lead to a wide range of health chronic concerns). Vitamins A and D are essential allies in the fighting of Cancer and Heart Disease, two major health concerns in the American population.

All of the organ meats are very high in both Iron and B12. These are again nutrients that are often deficient in most Americans. As my teacher, David Winston is fond of saying: the most unhealthy people in the world are the poor people in rich countries. Why? Because they have access to large quantities of nutritionally deficient food. This creates a situation in which they are consuming vast quantities of extremely refined carbohydrates and saturated or hydrogenated fats, and consuming miniscule amounts of essential nutrients. The result? Obesity and inflammation which gives way to diabetes, heart disease, and cancer, just to name a few.



The issue of meat is an issue of health, sustainability, and society. As a society, we are starving ourselves with excess, while nutrient-rich food is entirely wasted, or at best fed to our dogs. What I am getting at here, is that we have simply become too squeamish for our own good. Our pampered palettes can barely distinguish tastes, and are easily overwhelmed with the new and different. More importantly, though, the issue of meat is a social one: the eating of strange and non-mainstream meats is generally looked down upon by the average American, whose realm of comfort resides in the neighborhood of big-box stores, one-stop-shopping, and highly processed foods.

Traditional meats simply reek of self-sustaining traditional culture, of hard work and respect for the land, of close knit community. For many within the mainstream, they are also associated with a lower socioeconomic class. For some

reason, many of the aforementioned values and ways of being have not been the vogue for several decades now. They seem to hold the same sorts of connotations as thrift store shopping, and second hand appliances. Our inner American says "I want the best! I want new! Only the best and most expensive goods will do!" Well, I hope we can change all that, and return to a society that respects life, nature, and connectedness. It seems to me that this is the only change that will save us from destroying ourselves and our planet.

One more thing I have neglected to mention thus far: many of these fringe meats are quite easy on the pocketbook. That is something worth noting in economic times like these! No, I don't think that eating a diet of kidneys, tripe, and brains is going to save a family from bankruptcy, but it very well might help.

During the 1930's Great Depression, many Deitsch families didn't suffer the way the rest of the country did. Why was that? They provided for themselves and the made use of every scrap. My grandfather tells stories of saving tallow from meat all year long so that once every year his mother would hold a soap making marathon, turning rancid fat into floral wonders. He spoke of a garden brimming with sustenance on a tiny patch of ground behind a townhouse, and of the canned goods that filled the pantry of his childhood.

The shifting into a healthy society is a multi-faceted task and requires a view



of the bigger picture, and diet is only one slice of the pie. The attitudes we have toward our food, our decisions of what to eat, and how to obtain that food are things that have the potential for a global impact. Remember the old adage: think globally, act locally? How about this one: waste not, want not. Now it may seem an odd conclusion on the surface, but maybe going to your local butcher and ordering a block of scrapple is a revolutionary act. Perhaps, by eating of the marginal meats, you will be able to contemplate the true sacrifice involved in the necessity of eating flesh. Even more immediate: by involving yourself with a local business, and avoiding the big box supermarket, you might make a friend and become more than a resident of your locale, you may find yourself becoming part of a community.

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Below, Elijah tastes some scrapple, one of his favorite breakfast meats



Marvelous Mouthwatering Marginal Meats

By Jesse Tobin

In the previous article I've stated many reasons for the eating of various delectable, yet often ignored meats. That is all fine and good, they may be tasty, morally sound, inexpensive, and nutrient rich, but few among the younger generations have the faintest clue how to prepare them. Let me be clear, I have not, in fact, tasted or tested all of the organs I've spoken of above. I have, however, experimented with several, thanks to the help of my mom, my Oma, and my horde of trusty cookbooks. I cannot, with ethical integrity, share and recommend recipes that I have not first tested myself. With this in mind, I commit, to test a new organ meat or other marginal delicacy each quarter, and to share my findings and recipes with you. My family will simply have to endure my experiments!

Liver

Liver is probably my favorite of the fringe meats. It is also one that is loathed on principle by many who detest the fact that it is a "filter". To this I simply site the example of nature: the carnivore that accomplishes the kill of its prey has the choice of all cuts of this animal. What does the predator choose? The liver. The liver is quite simply the most nutrient

dense part of the body. Due to the fact that it is a filter, I recommend that people eating liver choose to eat the livers of organically raised and pastured animals. Of course, I recommend that all animal products consumed be from organic and pastured sources, anyway!

As I said before, Liver is extremely rich in Vitamins A and D, as well as Iron and B12 (just to mention a few). It is an ideal meat for those who suffer from anemia, or vitamin deficiencies.

Rumaki

When it comes right down to it, the best way to eat liver is with bacon! I am not going to lie, liver is a strong tasting meat. Here is a recipe that gets even liver haters to salivate!

1lb chicken or beef livers
1lb bacon
2 cans water chestnuts (sliced)
Tamari soy sauce
white wine
1 pack toothpicks

Preheat the oven to 375 degrees (Fahrenheit). Cut the livers into 1inch cubes with a sharp knife. Place one slice of water chestnut on top of each piece of liver. Wrap the liver and water chestnut into little packages with the bacon, and secure the package with a toothpick. Arrange these tiny packages in a baking dish and pour over them a few splashes of tamari and wine. Place the dish in the oven and bake for 15-20 minutes, or until the liver is cooked through (you will have to open one to check).

This is a wonderful recipe for parties and potlucks. People who believe themselves to be liver haters try these tasty morsels unwittingly and promptly ask for the recipe. And there you have it: a conversion!

Liver and Onions

Here is the old standby, the classic liver recipe. This is a dish that can sometimes still be found at restaurants (particularly diners).

2lb chicken or beef livers
2 medium sized onions
1 cup flour (I use half sorghum and half cornstarch for gluten free flour mix)
2 TBS spice mix- this is up to your taste: a hot pepper or curry blend can be nice and cut the thick flavor of the liver, but a more traditional blend would be something like sage, salt and pepper.
Butter
1/2lb bacon, cooked and cooled

Begin by preheating the oven to 200 degrees. Slice the onions and set them to saute with some butter in a skillet. In a wide, flattish bowl, crush the bacon into bits. Add the flour and spice mix to this bowl and stir until thoroughly mixed. Find a large skillet and set it to heat up on the stove. Medium high heat should be good. Place a slice of butter on the skillet so that it begins to melt. Lay each piece of liver in the flour mixture and press it flat into the mixture on each side so that it is well coated. Place the now coated piece into the hot skillet and fry it up! When each piece is well cooked on both sides, place it in a baking dish in the oven (just to keep it warm while the others are frying).

This recipe pairs well with Parsley mashed potatoes, and just about any cooked greens.

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The Wunjo – Bliss

by Patrick Donmoyer

"Bliss he enjoys who knows not suffering, sorrow nor anxiety,
and has prosperity and happiness and a good enough house."

-Anglo Saxon Rune Poem, Northvegr Foundation

The eighth rune Wunjo, translated from the Anglo Saxon as "Joy," "Bliss," or occasionally by some authors as "Glory," is comparable to the modern German Word "Wonne." The shape and form of this rune is similar to the Latin letter P, with a more angular loop intersecting the upright stave. As the Anglo Saxon poem suggests, this rune signifies the momentary state of being when one relinquishes the human tendency to grapple with the past and the future and embraces the present.

"Suffering" and "sorrow" are often linked to the regretting of past occurrences and an inability to see the present clearly and constructively. The past is rooted in memory, while the future is projected by thought. Bliss as the ancient poem indicates is also a freedom from obsession with future expectations, as this is certainly the cause of "anxiety."

The rune poem also speaks of bliss on a second level: as it concerns material stability. The reference to a "good enough house," is not merely illustrating a building, but also the interconnection of the household as the familial occupants and purpose of the house. Although "good enough" could seem like an unusually bland way to describe a house which brings one bliss, perhaps the poem suggests that the root of joy does not rely upon an ideal perfection.

The experience of bliss is rather an embracing of the limitations of the present circumstances despite apparent imperfections, thus becoming a recipient of peace. Wunjo does not appear to imply bliss as a result of having every wish one desires, nor does it indicate a prosperity from riches or material excess. Wunjo is symbolic of each individual's and each community's relation to acceptance of present circumstances, and the ability to find joy in what is present.

On yet another level, Wunjo is symbolic of a transcendent joy, which strips the individual of the fetters of materiality and the anxiety of mortality. Bliss is the antithesis of the fear of death, which characterizes and shapes many aspects of human behavior. Wunjo in its transcendent meaning is linked in this particular sense to non-ordinary experience, achieved through prayer,



shamanic practice, sexual intimacy and the intuition of ecstasy. It is no mistake that Wunjo is the eighth rune: to the Ancient Germanic and Scandinavian peoples, as well as the Romans and Greeks, the number eight was a symbol of completion. It is a number related to the physical plane, as a circle with eight spokes refers to the four cardinal directions and four mid-points, establishing a sense of orientation and stability. To the Scandinavians the number eight depicted as a wheel has additional references the nine worlds – eight of which form the spokes on the periphery, with a ninth in the central hub – signifying the world of humanity surrounded by the eight other mythical worlds. The symbol of the wheel has also carried with it for generations the implications of the agricultural process and its connection to fate. Wunjo invites humanity to step outside of its conventional boundaries of comfort to embrace the bliss which is available through the relinquishment of attempted control, and a surrendering to the vulnerability to fate. Bliss can be experienced therefore even in the midst of the most difficult circumstances.

In divination, Wunjo is emblematic of a blissful state of being . When cast upright, it is always a positive sign of an attitude which has the ability to transcend difficulties and find peace and fulfillment even in the midst of conflict. When inverted, Wunjo can indicate that a querent is unable to temporarily suspend the tendency towards an obsession with past regrets or expectations of a not-yet-manifest future. As always, each rune must be considered in context, and as in the case of the divinatory method described in last issue's article, the rune in the upper-most position of the five-rune cross method can offer potential assistance despite a possible inversion of beneficial runes such as Wunjo. Wunjo in an inverted position can indicate that the querent is not ready to be released from concern as a result of necessary introspection as a part of the growth process. This despite apparent negativity can be a blessing in disguise. Bliss is a momentary intuition, and not realistic as a permanent state of being. It is the moment of transformation, and therefore cannot be stable and unchanging.

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From the Wife's Perspective

by Jesse Tobin



Building a home is not for the faint of heart. Even when the home is built by a third party, the constant queue of questions asked and decisions to be made, of deadlines and paperwork is overwhelming to say the least. When the only contract you have is with yourself, when the volunteer labor falls through, when the work falls behind the schedule, the stress is unimaginable. This, however, is simply the reality of building a home with the two hands God gave you.

I've played a very traditional role during the process of building. Due to the fact that our son was so small at the onset, there was little I could do but provide food and emotional support to the men who came home sopping wet from yet another rainy weekend. Up until very recently this has been the extant of what I am able to do: cook for hungry men, schlep the food, coffee and utensils up to the land, dole it out, schlep it back, clean up, and start on the next round. My past twelve months has

revolved around baby, food, and dishes. Never in my life have I experienced such an extreme divide of labor. I've found myself falling back on the traditional housewife's weekly calendar: Muundaag iss die Wescherei, Diensdaag iss die Butzerei (Monday is the washday, Tuesday is the cleaning day), and so on. I find that if I don't keep to this schedule, it is inevitable that the simple upkeep of life becomes a whirling dust pile of chaos ready to consume my house with me in it!!!

What has been wonderful about this time is the bonding that has happened between the members of our family and community. My mother, mother in law, sister, sister in law, and even grandparents have all jumped in to tow the rope when we could not. They've heaved Somerbeams into place, wired, plumbed, sawed, and shoveled. The women have stood by my side over countless bubbling pots of stew, changed diapers while I ran to the hardware store (for the third time in one day), or simply spent day after day with an ever more mobile and exploratory toddler.

As a whole, the process of building has galvanized relationships within our families as well as our wider community of friends. When I see Matthew leave the house day after day with barely time to say "good morning" to his wife and son, and work the day through until after Elijah has gone to bed, I know there is nothing more heartening to him than 5 good friends ready to put up a roof early on a saturday morning.

Now, however, we are entering into a whole new level of stress. We both have a love/hate relationship with the impending date of May 1st. On one hand, neither of us can wait for that day to come. In order to receive the Federal government's $8000 tax credit for new home owners, we have to have all our paperwork signed by that date. As of May first we will be free of the ever-building pressure to finish, we will have made it or not, and either way there will be a certain amount of relief just in knowing our fate. On the other hand, there is so much to be done, and so much pressure until then that we are continually wishing we had just one more week, one more month to finish things off. The pace of our lives is unbelievable. We both wish we could just plug our ears and close our eyes and sleep until the first of May. The only problem is that no one else is going to finish our project for us!

So here we sit, one of our most beloved and sacred days of the year has become our personal Judgement Day! Luckily there is enough Scorpio in each of us (and even more to go around in the rest of our family!) to keep on obsessing, eating, cooking, and plugging away until this crazy undertaking is finished (enough).

It was no joke when I told everyone that I considered this house project to be Matthew's pregnancy. But following that line of thought, I think we are now clearly in active labor and preparing to push! Matthew is clearly living in the whirlwind of focus, pain, and stress that surrounds the birthing woman, and I am most definitely as strained and exhausted as any birth partner. His gestational period and labor, however, are sadly substantially longer than mine! I am continuously awed at his endurance. I am experiencing all of the emotions that he described after the birth of our son. We just have to keep our eye on the prize, and also remind ourselves that Matthew will only have to do this once!!!

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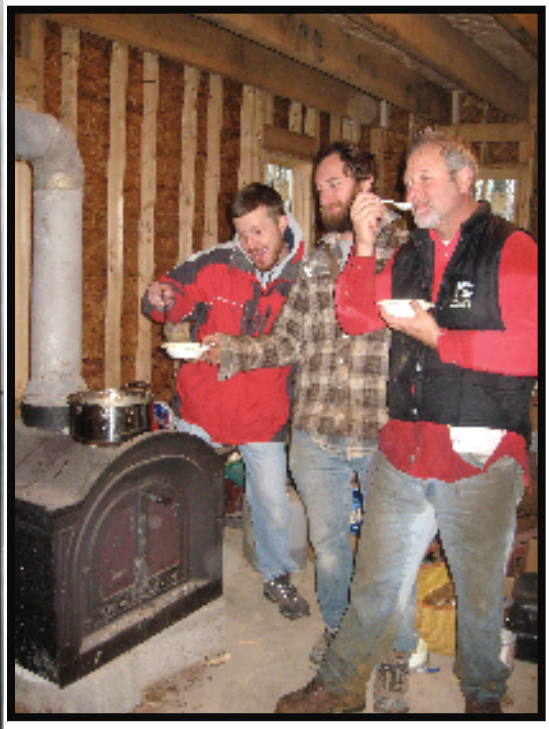
















Brennessel

Stinging Nettle, Dwarf Nettle
Urtica dioica, Urtica urens
By Jesse Tobin

Appearance:

Stinging Nettle is a perennial herb that appears in the early spring as a small herbaceous plant. By the end of the season it reaches a height of 12-50 inches. Nettle leaves are mostly oval shape, coming to barely a heart shape at the base. The greenish flowers arrive in branched clusters in June and continue as late as September. The seeds arrive thereafter.

Nettle is a naturalized European weed, and is generally found in waste places throughout most of the United states.

Harvest:

The stinging properties of this plant, though unfortunate when encountered in the wild (and somewhat avoidable depending on the season of harvest), are quieted either by boiling or drying the fresh plant. Of course caution must be taken when the plant is harvested to wear long gloves, boots, and pants. Once the leaves are dried, however, or else thrown into the pot to cook, they are entirely safe to touch with the bare hands (and of course to consume!). When harvesting the leaves of nettle it is best to gather the young tender growth of the spring. The young plants do not have such a strong sting to the skin. Nettle that has gone to seed should not be gathered for the use of its leaves, as this older growth can be so mineral rich that the chrystaline mineral structures can irritate the Urinary and Gastrointestinal tracts.

Culinary Uses:

First and foremost, nettle is a food herb. The leaves have been used for millennia as a potherb: cooked into stews and soups, steamed and buttered, or made into tea. I usually think of it as a culinary analog to spinach. Though it is a bit on the grainier side (due to its substantial mineral content), the taste and texture of the cooked leaves are very similar to Spinach and make a delightful addition to any recipe in which a mild-flavored cooking green is called for.

Medicinal Uses:

All parts of the nettle plant are medicinal: seed, leaf, and root. It has a neutral and dry nature.

Nettle seed is used in modern times as a restorative remedy to the kidneys. Though there have been few studies on it, the most successful uses of it have been in the case of degenerative kidney diseases. The seed also seems to be helpful in preventing kidney damage when used along with nephrotoxic pharmaceuticals.

Nettle leaf also acts as a tonic to the kidneys. Christopher Sauer used it to drive out kidney stones and promote urination. From a scientific viewpoint, this makes sense: Nettle is a very useful non- irritating, potassium sparing diuretic. As such it enhances the elimination of Uric Acid and other wastes in the urine (or as Sauer put it “all foul matter”). This explains its traditional usage not only in the prevention and elimination of kidney stones, but also in the treatment of Osteoarthritis, gout, and gouty arthritis. In the famous herbal written by John Gerard, a preparation is explained in which the nettle leaves and seeds are pulverized and drunk with red wine. This remedy, he explained was considered the singular medicine against kidney stones and the pain associated with them. Nettle is also helpful in easing hematuria (blood in the urine), which commonly occurs with the passage of kidney stones.

The leaf of Nettle is extremely

mineral rich. It is a wonderful blood tonic for those with anemic tendencies. It can be a supreme help to pregnant women with low blood iron. In addition to the iron benefit, the various other mineral components help to reduce the capillary fragility and varicose veins that often accompany pregnancy. Nettle strengthens the hair, skin and teeth, and is a very helpful supplement in the case of osteoporosis (particularly when used with other mineral rich herbs like horsetail and alfalfa). It is helpful in the healing of bone fractures and in the prevention of tooth decay.

The nettle leaf is also a mild lung tonic, with slight expectorant qualities. It was used traditionally in this capacity, and was recommended in this usage by both Sauer and Gerard.

The juice of nettle was traditionally used to stop bleeding. This was helpful as mentioned earlier in the case of blood in the urine. It was also used, however in the case of bloody sputum from the lungs, and was even snuffed up the nose in the case of a nosebleed.

The nettle root was traditionally used to treat long-standing jaundice. It was also listed as an effective cure for "dropsy" or edema by Sauer. This is most likely due to its tonic and diuretic effects on the kidney.

The root is also helpful as part of a formula in the case of Benign Prostatic Hyperplasia (BPH). Though not particularly strong in its effects alone, it is very helpful in combination with other herbs. There are some studies that show that it may even be helpful in the prevention of prostate cancer, and may also inhibit the growth and progression of this cancer.

Preparation:

As mentioned earlier, nettles has traditionally been used as a food as well as a medicine. Although many herbal medicines are best preserved in alcohol, alcohol



tinctures do not extract minerals very well. Due to this fact, the traditional preparation of the leaf would be to carefully dry the plant material and make it into tea. 1-2 teaspoons of leaf material would be used for each 8 ounces of water. The tea would be left to steep for one hour. This long steeping time allows for the minerals to extract well.

An infused vinegar is another way to extract nettle leaf, and it is one that has a longer shelf life! In this case the dried leaves could be placed in a jar and covered with apple cider or white vinegar and left to infuse for 14 days at least.

Continued on page 20.....

A Farm History: The Smokehouse

by Annie Hasz

Down the road from the farmhouse I live in you can find the modest ranch houses of my neighbors Sammy and Rachel and their spouses. Sammy and Rachel grew up in the house I now occupy and farmed the land my friends and I will farm this season. The farm hasn't grown anything but grass for a couple decades, but they can tell you about the days when their family raised chickens, pigs, cattle and an abundance of vegetables. We are slowly bringing the farm back to life and this especially delights Sammy. Thousands of vegetable seedlings have sprouted in our nursery, about three acres have been tilled and are in cover crops, garlic and strawberries, and there is a hearty flock of chickens and turkeys in the barn again. Little by little the farm is being reanimated by our work and reconnected with its history through the stories our neighbors tell.

Next to the farmhouse house are a butcher shop and a smokehouse both built in the 1920's. Sammy vividly remembers the smoking process because he was usually in charge of the fire. Hogs were often butchered in the winter, cured and then smoked. They put the hams in the basement in a salt and sugar brine. Every day the meat had to be covered with more brine until it stopped absorbing and developed a rind. Then it was ready to smoke. Hams and other meats were hung from hooks in the ceiling and a fire built in the cement compartment underneath the floor. The bottom compartment of the smokehouse is cement, and the wooden floor above has holes in it made by setting in mason jars when the cement was poured. The glass of the jars was broken to leave holes for the smoke to travel into hanging meats. They made the fire in the smokehouse with applewood, hickory or other hardwoods, stifled high flames with sawdust and kept it burning for about a week. If Sammy let the fire go out, the meat would freeze. He had to wake several times during the night and go outside to feed the fire.

Gideon Fisher, an Amish farmer from Lancaster who authored Farm Life and Its Changes (1978) remembers a similar experience of hog butchering and processing in the early 1900's. Amish families would usually butcher as many hogs as there were members of the family on a cold, clear day in December or January. In his community, several neighbors shared one smokehouse, usually a stone or brick building eight feet square and twelve feet high with a double floor. He notes that old-timers always preferred to season the hams with a hickory. The hams were then hung in the attic for further drying and curing. The attic in this farm house also has poles for hanging meat and the floor is stained from the drippings.

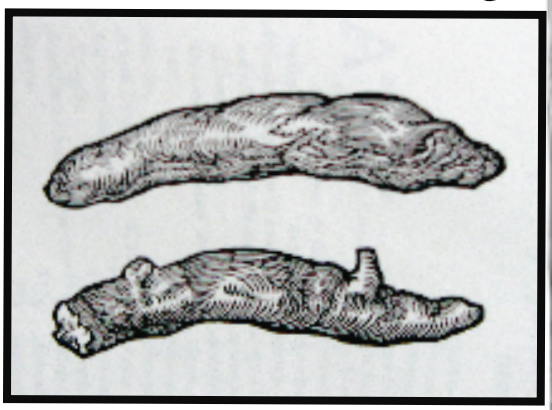
We may one day set up a smokehouse for our own meats. An idea from another vegetable farmer who uses his pigs in his pasture rotations is to smoke meat in the greenhouse in the winter. His smoking chamber is a converted refrigerator. He runs a pipe to this refrigerator from a small wood stove. The fire in the stove is partially regulated by a bellows attached to a thermostat, but still needs to be fed by hand. Other ideas are available at www.askthemeatman.com or check out the book Meat Smoking and Smokehouse Design by the Marianski family.

+ + +

Gilbwurz

Turmeric Curcuma longa

By Jesse Tobin



Appearance:

Turmeric does not grow in the continental United States. It grows in tropical regions, and much of the organically grown Turmeric available in the US is cultivated in Hawaii and Costa Rica. In appearance, the root looks much like that of the ginger plant. It is long, with many nodules, and has a brownish papery skin that sheathes a bright yellow center.

Harvest:

Turmeric can be successfully grown in pots in a green house year round. It does need very warm temperatures, and suffers when there is too little sun in the winter time. The roots can be purchased at some groceries whole and broken up to be planted in the soil of the pot. They must then be allowed to sprout, grow and develop larger roots over the course of many months. It is far more common to purchase the fresh root for immediate use or else to purchase the powdered root.

Culinary Uses:

The most common use of Turmeric among Deitsch farm families was as medicine. Turmeric was an exotic spice and had to be imported and purchased, so it was not used often in cooking until the late 1700's and into the 1800's. The most common place we find it after that time is in "indian pickles" more commonly known as Chow chow. Until the early nineteenth century these sorts of dishes were served primarily by the wealthy. At that time, Deitsch farmers would use saffron to add a yellow color to their dishes. After the early nineteenth century, however, Turmeric wiggled its way into many pickle recipes, bringing a distinctive flavor and color to an essential Deitsch food.

Medicinal Uses:

Since well before the time of Christopher Sauer Turmeric has been known for its beneficial effects on the liver. It is, of course, bright yellow (the color associated with the Choleric humor, also known as yellow bile), and thus seems to sing out its affinity for the liver in particular. Sauer lists it as a strong purifier of the liver, stomach, kidneys, and spleen. He explains that it frees all blockages of the choleric humors. He describes its benefit in the resolution of jaundice, and even includes it in a laxative formula.

In modern times we find that the benefits listed by Sauer are in fact quite accurate, if not understated. Turmeric seems to be a miracle for the liver. In this capacity, it has been found to assist strongly in phase I and phase II liver detox. It is also used as a hepatoprotective: protecting the liver from oxidative damage due to solvents, medication, or viruses. Turmeric's bitter flavor also gives it a strong cholagogue effect, increasing the flow of bile, and allowing for easier bile expulsion. This, in turn, strengthens not only the liver and gallbladder, but the entire digestive tract. Turmeric is used in herbal protocols for nearly any liver-related health issue: hepatic insufficiency, hepatitis, cirrhosis, fatty liver, hyperlipidemia, etc.

Another favorite use for turmeric among modern herbalists is as a systemic anti-inflammatory. It is used for a wide variety of inflammatory disorders: from sciatica and bursitis, to arthritis (both Osteo and Rheumatoid), to inflammatory skin issues like eczema, psoriasis, and roseacea.

Turmeric is incredibly anti-inflammatory to the circulatory system. It can be used to inhibit atherosclerosis. It can reduce circulatory blockages and inflammation and help to rebuild healthy tissue. It strengthens the circulatory tissues, even down to the level of capillaries. In this way it can assist in issues of poor circulation to the extremities and has a solid place in the supplement protocol for both type one and type two diabetics. Another boon for diabetics is that this wonderful herb can also help to reduce blood sugar levels, thus lowering the need for insulin therapy. This anti-inflammatory action in the circulatory system is also a benefit in the prevention of alzheimers-like conditions with dementia. It promotes cerebral circulation and prevents later life cerebral circulation issues like strokes and deteriorating vision.

Along this anti-inflammatory line, we also find turmeric to be a very helpful herb for inflammatory disorders of the GI tract. It assists in the control of such chronic disorders as: IBS, diverticulitis, mucus colitis, Crohn's disease, leaky gut syndrome, and food allergies in general (Celiac's disease especially). In this capacity it soothes, stabilizes, heals, and protects the mucus membranes of the guts. It assists in healing ulcers and prevents their formation. As part of a formula, it helps to relieve gas, nausea, borborygmus, and assists in the production of stomach acid when there is too little.



Turmeric reduces autoimmune response when it is used regularly as part of a formula. In this way it can help to stabilize inflammatory autoimmune conditions like Lupus, scleroderma, ankylosing spondylitis, Rheumatoid arthritis, Celiac's disease, and many many others. Turmeric has a very useful part in the treatment and prevention of allergies. Due to its high bioflavinoid content, it helps in the stabilization of mast cells, and thus in the reduction of the histamine response. It also has an anti-inflammatory effect that can be useful in the moment when an allergic response is in process.

Turmeric has antiviral and antibacterial activity. It is known to inhibit E. coli, Staph, Streptococcus, pathogenic fungi, as well as some viruses. This is perhaps one of the reasons it is so prominent in traditional Indian cooking: in a tropical climate, where refrigeration is hard (some parts of India still do not have modern conveniences), a food spice that helps to kill potential pathogens would be very welcome!

Last but most certainly not least, Turmeric has become very well known in recent years for its powerful antioxidant and anti-tumor activity. It is particularly helpful in the case of gastric, bowel, and oral cancers. It is also helpful, when applied topically for the inhibition of cervical dysplasias and carcinomas. David Winston and Donnie Yance, both well known herbalists familiar with alternative and complimentary treatments for cancer, rely

heavily on the use of Turmeric for a wide variety of cancers. It is a useful addition to nearly any cancer protocol.

Preparation:

Turmeric is most often used in its powdered form in cookery. It is part of most curry spice blends and gives a lovely yellow color to any food it is added to. For an easy and at home supplement, the powder can be mixed with ghee (clarified butter) in a 2:1 ratio, chilled, and then formed into small pills (keep them chilled for ease of ingestion).

The tea is made from the dried root or root powder. 1/2 tsp root to 8oz water. It should steep for at least a half hour before it is drunk. The tea itself is not particularly good tasting, and is best when combined with other herbs. The tea also has the tendency to stain the teeth a yellow color when it is taken on a regular basis.

Turmeric is often taken as a tincture, it is made as a fresh extract 1:2 in a 60% alcohol menstrum.

Turmeric is an excellent addition to any herbal vinegars or oils. These can be used both as flavoring agents in cooking as well as medicinal carriers.

Cautions:

Turmeric should not be used in medicinal doses during pregnancy. Spice amounts in cooking is fine.

Standardized extracts with extremely high ratios of curcumin (an active constituent in turmeric) can irritate and exacerbate gastric ulcers and mucosa.

Turmeric should not be used in large doses when a history of kidney stones is present. Some studies have shown that consumption of medicinal doses of Turmeric can promote the formation of kidney stones in those who have this tendency.

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Weaver, William Woys. *Sauer's Herbal Cures: America's First Book of Botanic Healing*. New York: Routledge, 2001.

Winston, David. *Notes from Herbal Therapeutics School of Botanical Medicine 2 year course*. Washington, New Jersey, 2004-2006.

Yance, Jr., Donald. *Herbal Medicine, Healing, and Cancer: a Comprehensive Program for Prevention and Treatment*. Chicago, Il, 1999.

Nettles continued from page 15.....

The root and seed of the nettle plant should be prepared as an alcohol tincture. The menstrum should be at least 30% alcohol for proper extraction.

Cautions:

* Contact with raw or fresh nettles can cause a severe and painful rash, avoid touching the fresh plant, and do not eat the leaves before they are dried or cooked.
* Do not use concurrently with digoxin, lanoxin, or lithium.

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Duke, James A., and Foster, Steven. *Eastern/Central Medicinal Plants*. *New York: Houghton Mifflin Company, 1990*.

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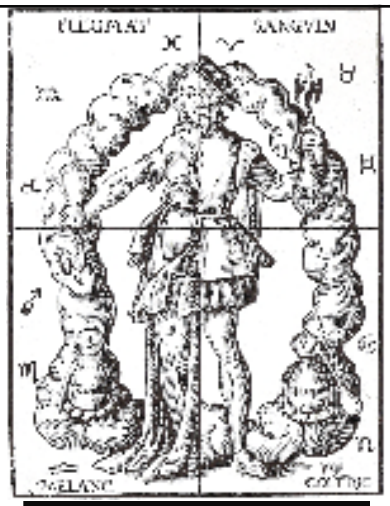
+++ Hermetic influence upon the tradition

+++ History and mystical traditions of the reformation

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+++ Native American influence Twentieth century Braucherei

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There will be no guild gatherings until the end of June 2010. Upcoming events will be listed in the next issue of Hollerbeier Haven, as well as on our website:

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